# Owl and the Pussycat

## By Bill Manhoff

**DORIS:** Read me your story.

**FELIX:** (Picks up typewriter script) You won't like it.

**DORIS:** I'll love it.

**FELIX:** (Reading.) Scream –

**DORIS:** "Scream." That's the title, right – "Scream."

**FELIX:** Yes.

**DORIS:** That's a wild title.

**FELIX:** Thank you. (Reads) The sun spit morning into Werner's face – one eyelid fluttered – dragging the soul back screaming from its stealthy flight to death –

**DORIS:** The sun spit morning into this guy's face?

**FELIX:** Yes.

**DORIS:** You were right.

**FELIX:** When?

**DORIS:** I don't like it. I hate it. The sun spit morning into his face! What right do you have to put down a terrible thing like that in a story – "The sun spit morning in a man's face."

**FELIX:** All right - - you don't like it – but calm down.

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## INTRODUCTION

*ACTRESS: Felix is a "writer". He also considers himself an intellectual. He is snobby, elitist, and finicky.*
*ACTOR: Doris is a prostitute who lives across the alley.*
*ACTRESS: Felix has basically been spying on Doris with binoculars -- he tells the landlord of her building about her extra-curricular activities and Doris gets thrown out of her apartment.*
*ACTOR: She finds out that Felix is the one who turned her in - so she comes knocking on his door, dragging a suitcase and her television set - demanding that he put her up until she can find a new place.*
*ACTRESS: The relationship progresses and Felix decides that Doris is train-able - he starts giving her little tasks - she is supposed to look up a word a day in the dictionary and then use it in a sentence.*
*ACTOR: Not exactly a match made in Heaven . . . but for Doris and Felix it seems to work TOGETHER: The Owl and the Pussycat by Bill Manhoff*

USE ONLY

**DORIS:** You know what you are? Your inflabious (hic)

**FELIX:** Inflabious?

**DORIS:** Yeah

**FELIX:** What does that mean?

**DORIS:** (thumbing her nose.) Ah ha! How does it feel? I'm not gonna tell you!

**FELIX:** You just made up a word?

**DORIS:** How do I know you're not making up yours?

**FELIX:** Mine are in the dictionary.

**DORIS:** That's your story!

**FELIX:** I suppose it never occurred to you that as an alternative to getting angry, you might make some attempt to understand whatever it is that confuses you?

**DORIS:** Why? Why should I? What about people making some attempt to not confuse me? (hic)

**FELIX:** Because progress does not lie in the pampering of the brainless.

**DORIS:** Drop - (Hic) dead! Damn it!

**FELIX:** Hold your breath

**DORIS:** Hold yours . . .

**FELIX:** Maybe you can hiccup yourself to sleep.

**DORIS:** You better not be so funny – people have been known to – (His) die from the hiccups.

**FELIX:** Drink a glass of water.

**DORIS:** That never works with me. Only one thing words with me – you gotta scare me.

**FELIX:** How the devil am I gonna scare a holy terror like you?

**DORIS:** (Hic.) I get them very deep – it's a strain on the heart, so stop fooling around and scare me – (Hic.) or I'll scream (Felix turns and walks around the sofa – suddenly pounces with clawed hands snarling like a tiger.) O come – (Hic) on! (Felix drops down behind sofa – Doris hiccups twice. Felix suddenly appears on all fours around the end of the sofa rising menacingly and hissing like a asnake.) It's no use. I was expecting it. You have to do it when I'm not – (Hic.) expecting it.

**FELIX:** Oh, that's ridiculous! How can I do that? You're waiting for me to frighten you.

**DORIS:** Well, mate me – (hic.) forget about it – stupid. Then when my mind is on – (Hic) something else – then do it.

**FELIX:** When your mind is on something else!

**DORIS:** Of course, stupid! Change the subject – put me off my – (hic) guard.

**FELIX:** Some weather we're having. It's a wonderful summer, isn't it?

**DORIS:** Beautiful (Hic)

**FELIX:** I think it's quite a bit warmer than it was last year at this time Don't you?

**DORIS:** Come on, will you – you want me to hiccup to death? (hic)

**FELIX:** I'm putting you off your guard!

**DORIS:** I'm off my (hic) guard by now. Stupid!

**FELIX:** You're expecting it now.

**DORIS:** I am not (hic) Com on, will you! (Felix gives a hideous roar. Doris looks at Felix for a second, then) You're right. I was (hic) expecting it.

**FELIX:** Listen – I'm through- I'm finished – I'm exhausted. I just don't care. I'm going to bed! (Felix exits to bedroom. Doris turns facing audience)

**DORIS:** Dirty (hic) fink! (Behind her Felix creeps on tiptoe from the bedroom) Rotten (hic) pervert. I could die for all he cares (hic). I could die right . . . (Suddenly Felix growls and puts his hands around Doris' neck. Doris jumps in terror. She turns and clouts Felix in the face)

**FELIX:** What's the idea!

**DORIS:** You wanna give somebody a heart attack? You maniac, you wanna kill me?

(Felix takes a deep breath, calms himself and then changes the subject)

**FELIX:** How many times did you say you used the dictionary today?

**DORIS:** I don't know.

**FELIX:** Please go over to the dictionary and look at it closely.

**DORIS:** [*Doris goes and looks at the dictionary*] What am I supposed to see?

**FELIX:** Look at the edges -- at the top --

**DORIS:** What's this? [*Peeling off a strip of scotch tape*]

**FELIX:** That is a strip of Scotch tape. It's been there for two days. Undisturbed. Where were you this afternoon?

**DORIS:** That's such a nasty thing to do.

**FELIX:** Where were you yesterday afternoon?

**DORIS:** I do not care for the tone of your voice.

**FELIX:** Where did you get the dirty but brand new radio?

**DORIS:** I'm warning you -- stop it -- this warning will not be repeated.

**FELIX:** We're not going to fight anymore. We're going to have an honest unemotional discussion.

**DORIS:** Yeah? So you start out by calling me a liar.

**FELIX:** I did not call you a liar. I'm not going to lose my temper.

**DORIS:** You might as well. I'm gonna lose mine!

**FELIX:** Would you care to tell me what's wrong?

**DORIS:** What's wrong? You're a creep that puts scotch tape on the dictionary -- you know that word -- "creep"? Used in a sentence: "Fred Sherman is a big creep".

**FELIX:** [*starting at "Fred"*] What did you call me?

**DORIS:** It's your name. Fred -- Freddie -- I thought that would jar your apricots! I found your yearbook from school -- Fred Sherman. You didn't tell me you changed your name, did you? You creep. I'm sorry -- pardon my language, but you are a creep.

**FELIX:** It's all right -- it's a step up from "fink". Congratulations -- now -- I'd like to hear why you feel you have to sneak out afternoons and lie to me.

**DORIS:** I just got bored. I had to get out. Look -- I tried. I tried working on hats. I tried looking for a job, right? I tried.

**FELIX:** Have you been plying your old trade?

**DORIS:** Have I been what? No, I haven't. I told you I was through doing that.

**FELIX:** Where'd you get the radio?

**DORIS:** I collected some money. Somebody owed me some money and they paid me.

**FELIX:** I see. Why didn't you tell me that?

**DORIS:** Because I knew you wouldn't believe it. I knew what you'd think.

**FELIX:** I see.

**DORIS:** Dont' say "I see", like you were looking through your lousy spy glasses. Listen -- why don't you stop trying to make out like you're a human being? I mean the strain must be terrible -- why don't you just relax and admit you're God and you know all about everything?

**FELIX:** Why did you have to lie? I just want to know why you lied to me about going out and about looking up words.

**DORIS:** Because I'm a liar, okay?

**FELIX:** Why didn't you tell me?

**DORIS:** Why didn't you tell me you changed your name from Fred to Felix?

**FELIX:** [*ignoring her question*] I'm very sad. You had a chance to do something important for yourself and you're quitting. You're not giving yourself a chance.

**DORIS:** I gave myself a chance -- you had me going there for a while, but it's silly. I'm a dope and that's all there is to it.

**FELIX:** You're not a dope. You're a bright girl.

**DORIS:** Not when it comes to dictionaries and the history of philosophy, I'm not.

**FELIX:** You have a potential capacity for --

**DORIS:** No, I don't have any potential anything.

**FELIX:** [*losing the fight against his temper*] Don't interrupt me -- who do you think is better qualified to judge mental capacity -- you or I?

**DORIS:** You --

**FELIX:** Then why are you arguing with me?

**DORIS:** Felix, I --

**FELIX:** Would I be wasting my time with you if you didn't have a brain?

**DORIS:** Felix --

**FELIX:** Do you think an intellectual such as myself would waste his time with a dumbbell?

**DORIS:** Felix, I know myself -- you can't tell me --

**FELIX:** I tell you you're a very intelligent girl, and you'd know it yourself if you weren't so damned stupid!

**DORIS:** I am not stupid! I've got good healthy everyday brains. I haven't got your kind of brains and I'm glad, because I'm gonna tell you something -- I think your brains are rotten!

**FELIX:** Ah -- the cat turns inevitably and bares her atavistic fangs.

**DORIS:** To use those ugly, lonely words nobody else uses -- that's all your brains are good for. To keep people away because you're scared to death of people!

**FELIX:** She spits in inarticulate fury!

**DORIS:** You know what your brains are good for? To make up your own lousy little language that the rest of the world can't even understand.

**FELIX:** Well, all right -- stay with the rest of the world -- don't let anybody make you a foreigner there by teaching you to speak the English language!

**DORIS:** [*going to closet*] What a dope I was to listen to you. [*Mimicking him*] I'm gonna save you, Doris! [*In her own voice*] You are such a phony. I can't believe it. You don't write for money but you keep sending your junk to magazines, don't you? And you keep getting it sent back, don't you? Meanwhile all you got is a phony job, a phony girlfriend, a phony apartment and a phony bunch of words. [*she has taken the suitcase from the closet and started to throw garments into it as she talks*]

**FELIX:** What are you doing?

**DORIS:** What does it look like I'm doing?

**FELIX:** Now don't get washed away. Think, Doris, try to understand one basic thing. Try to hold on to what I see in you.

**DORIS:** [*Yelling*] You see nothing! You don't see me at all! You don't see anything. Because even your eyes are phony! You are now and forever, a miserable magazine peddler named Freddie Sherman and a lousy writer and you always will be and you wanna know why --? [*Hitting him deliberately with every word*] Because, The -- sun -- does -- not -- spit!

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

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